

A photograph of a blue door with a wooden frame. A doormat with a blue fringe and a tan center is placed in front of the door. The text "SABBATH" is written in white on a dark blue circular background at the top. The text "GROWING WELCOMING HEARTS!" is written in large, bold, blue letters on the doormat. The text "MEMORY VERSE" is written in brown on the left side. The text "Behold, I stand at the door and knock. If anyone hears My voice and opens the door, I will come in to him and dine with him, and he with Me. Revelation 3:20 NKJV" is written in black and brown on the right side. The page number "61" is written in white on a brown circular background at the bottom right.

SABBATH

GROWING WELCOMING HEARTS!

MEMORY VERSE

Behold, I stand at the door and knock. If anyone hears
My voice and opens the door, I will come in to him and
dine with him, and he with Me. Revelation 3:20 NKJV

When John wrote his vision of heaven in Revelation 7, he described a vast crowd of people before God's throne. The King of the Universe was welcoming His beloved children from more communities, centuries, and cultures that we can ever imagine.

The Creator who lavished our world with diversity at creation, is delighted by the diversity of human beings who choose to follow His loving way. He doesn't mind the color of their skin, their language, their abilities, their age, their gender, or whether they are rich or poor. He loves

them all the same, whatever they have done or not done. Many of them have never heard of God, Jesus, or the Bible!

But they responded to the Holy Spirit, a quiet voice deep in their hearts, that taught them to be kind, loving, and generous towards others.

When we help our children to listen to the voice of the Holy Spirit, and to be kind and loving towards those who think, look, speak, behave, and believe differently to them, then we teach them to have a heart that welcomes everybody to the kingdom of God, just like their Father in heaven.

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INTRODUCTION KNOCK, KNOCK...

GROWING WELCOMING HEARTS

Read together
1 Corinthians 12

Paul was writing a letter to his friends in Rome. He remembered all the different people, and how much they loved Jesus! He sighed because it wasn't always easy for them to get along. How could he help them understand that their differences were blessings?

He thought about his own body. His hand held the pen. His eyes helped him to see the words. His mind thought about what he was writing, and his heart was filled with the love of God for all his friends in Rome.

The Holy Spirit inspired him to write that they were like the parts of a body. They all had different jobs to do, so that everyone was cared for. At the center of their 'body' was a heart filled with God's love, and the mind of their body was inspired by the Holy Spirit. Each person had a unique responsibility to care for the others, just as our noses are different to our legs, but they take care of us in different

ways! Everyone in the church needs to help each other and care for each other.

Paul explained that the Holy Spirit had given each of them at least one gift to bless others and show them God's love. Some of them had strong faith and they could encourage other people. Some were good teachers or preachers, and they could help people to understand more about God's generous love and forgiveness. Some people were gifted to care for others. Some had been blessed with extra resources to share with those in need. And some were good leaders. When everyone used their special gifts generously and cheerfully, everyone in the church was blessed, and they would experience more of God's love together.

When other people saw how much they loved each other, they would want to join their loving community too!

Paul wrote simple and helpful instructions about being kind and loving. He encouraged them to respect each other's differences. To comfort each other when they were sad. To celebrate and be happy together. To invite each other to their homes. To be patient. To bless each other. And to live peacefully together (Romans 12). Paul knew they would experience a little bit of heaven on earth if they chose to live together in harmony, and their church would grow if they welcomed those who were different to themselves.

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John, one of Jesus' disciples, had a special vision of heaven. He saw a beautiful picture of a vast gathering of people! They were from every country, tribe, language, and family! They were as different as anyone could ever imagine! They were all dressed in white robes, and they stood before the throne of God, worshipping Him, with joy and love and wonder! (Revelation 7:9)

And God was filled with joy and love! This is the moment He had been waiting for! All His beloved children were together at last! They were all very different, but they were all very welcome! And now they would all live together in peace and love, forever and ever.

GROWING WELCOMING HEARTS

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MEMORY VERSE ACTIVITIES

- As you learn this memory verse together, stand at a door, knock, be welcomed in and sit down at the table together.

PRAYER ACTIVITIES

GIFTED!

- Read and list spiritual gifts from Romans 12:6-8, 1 Corinthians 12:7-11, and 1 Peter 4:10-11 on a gift bag or box for reminders.
- Thank God for these special gifts in His community.
 - Identify which gifts the Holy Spirit has given each of you. Pray for guidance in using these gifts to bless others and reveal God's love.
 - Using our gifts to bless others brings blessings to ourselves as well!

HEAVEN

- Read Revelation 7 and discuss the diverse worship of God depicted there, recognizing you are included in this picture!
- Pray for those who don't know God yet, that they will join in this worship.
- Pray for people different from you, that they will heed the Holy Spirit and come to know Jesus.
- Ask the Holy Spirit to guide you in using your spiritual gifts to welcome others and show them God's love.

FAMILY ACTIVITIES

MISSING PIECE?

- Find a picture of Jesus or draw one on a sheet of paper.
- Cut the picture into at least 20 pieces and give everyone some of the pieces. Secretly hide one piece.
- Work together to assemble the picture of Jesus.
- How does it feel when one piece is missing? When we don't use our spiritual gifts, something is missing in our family or church.
- How might God feel about each person who is missing from His family? Search for the lost piece of the puzzle and remember how God feels about each of His missing sheep or children.
- When you complete the puzzle, celebrate! And remember that the celebration in heaven when we are all gathered at the throne of God will be millions of times bigger than any celebration we can ever imagine!

IMAGINING THE FAMILY REUNION!

- Read Revelation 7.
- Draw a picture of your family at the huge reunion in heaven.
- What song would you sing to praise God at this moment?
- Choose a hymn you know, or write a new praise song of your own, and sing it to a familiar tune.

EARTH MADE NEW!

- Gather craft materials and boxes.
- Discuss what the new earth might be like: envision a village with diverse people and different kinds of houses, considering needs like shops, playgrounds, roads, churches, gardens, and gathering places.
- Use materials to create a model home for your family in the new earth.
- Imagine living in this amazing place with diverse people forever—it will surpass our imaginations, but we can enjoy sharing ideas together.

SABBATH SNAPSHOT!

THE VERSE

Behold, I stand at the door and knock. If anyone hears My voice and opens the door, I will come in to him and dine with him, and he with Me. Revelation 3:20 NKJV

THE INTRODUCTION

Teaching children to listen to the Holy Spirit and be kind to those different from them teaches them to welcome everyone to God’s kingdom, like their heavenly Father.

THE DEVOTIONAL

Paul wrote simple and helpful instructions about being kind and loving. He encouraged them to respect each other’s differences.

THE PRAYER

Identify which gifts the Holy Spirit has given each of you. Pray for guidance in using these gifts to bless others and reveal God’s love.

THE CONVERSATION

Write down actionable ideas that your family can follow to cultivate loving hearts. Review this list in a month to assess what works and what needs updating.